What Is a Core Job?

Describe what the user is trying to accomplish—not what the product does.

A Core Job is a meaningful goal a user is trying to achieve in a particular context. It describes the progress the user wants to make, independent of any one feature or implementation. Features are possible ways a product can help; they are not the job itself.

Why the distinction matters

Jobs are user-centred

They start from the user's purpose, situation and desired progress—not from the product's menu or feature set.

Features are solution-centred

They describe product behavior or capability, such as saving a list, filtering results or sending a notification.

The job helps evaluate scope

A feature earns its place when it contributes to a meaningful outcome or necessary step in the core journey.

The central idea

Start by asking what the user is trying to accomplish and why it matters. Only then ask what product capabilities might support that job. The same job may be supported by different solutions, and one feature may support several jobs.

Avoid this trap

"Users need recommendations" describes a possible solution. Ask what users are trying to achieve when they seek recommendations.

Core Job or product feature?

The wording is a clue: jobs usually describe a user goal in context; features usually describe an action or capability provided by the product.

CORE JOB · USER GOAL

“Choose a book that fits my interests and the time I have available.” It describes the progress the reader wants to make.

FEATURE · PRODUCT CAPABILITY

“Show personalized book recommendations.” It describes one possible product behavior that may help with the job.

OUTCOME · WHAT CHANGES FOR THE USER

“I can confidently select a suitable next book without spending too much time searching.” It describes the intended result, not the mechanism.

WHY THE DIFFERENCE MATTERS

If the job is clear, you can compare several ways to help. If you start with a feature, you may mistake one proposed solution for the user’s underlying need.

Question to ask

If this feature disappeared, would the user’s goal still matter? Could another approach help the user accomplish it?

From user goal to product scope

A Core Job should help you reason from user intent to product capability without jumping directly from a feature request to implementation.

A simple connection

CONTEXT	When does the user need to make progress?
CORE JOB	What are they trying to accomplish in that context?
OUTCOME	What would successful progress look like for them?
CAPABILITY	What kind of support might help them achieve it?
FEATURE	What specific product behavior could provide that support?

Scope test

Keep a feature only when there is a clear rationale linking it to a user outcome, core journey or explicit learning goal.

Quick self-check: job or feature?

Review a proposed feature or a statement about user needs. Tick the items that are true of your current reasoning.

Self-check

- [ ] The Core Job is written as a user goal, not a product function.
- [ ] The user context is clear enough to understand why the job matters.
- [ ] The intended outcome is distinct from the feature used to achieve it.
- [ ] More than one possible solution could be considered.
- [ ] The feature's contribution to the job or outcome is explained.
- [ ] The feature is not included solely because someone requested it.
- [ ] Important assumptions about the user's job are visible.
- [ ] The core journey still works with the selected scope.

Apply it to your idea

The user in context is trying to…

The desired outcome is…

The feature or capability that may help is…

Takeaway

Define the job before selecting the feature. User intent gives product scope its rationale.